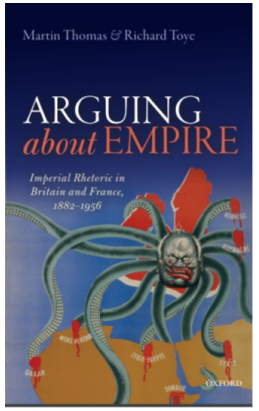
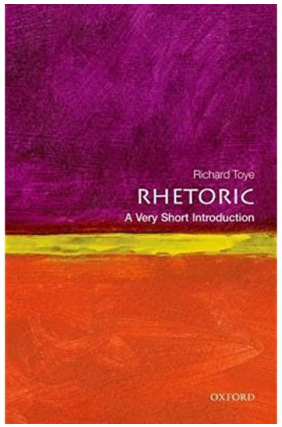
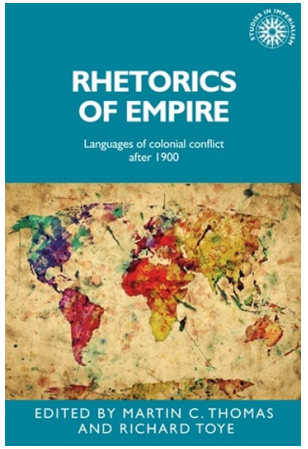
How to Write a Compelling Nonfiction Book Proposal

Richard Toye
Professor, Historian, Author



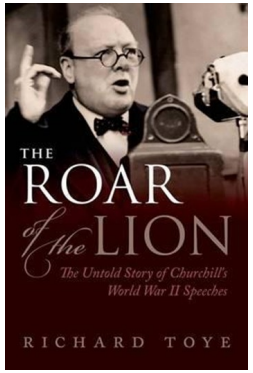


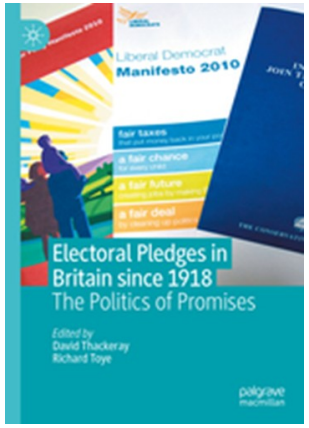


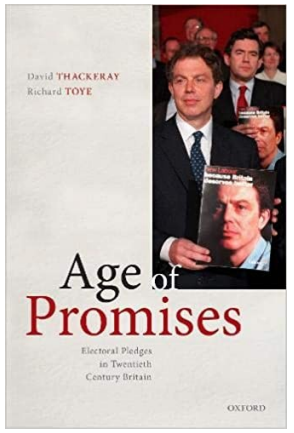
I have published 19 non-fiction books (including edited and co-authored volumes).

I frequently provide assessments of proposals for publishers.

Literary Director of Royal Historical Society; long experience of Ph.D. supervision and mentoring.







Course contents

Session 1: General principles.

- Why write a book proposal?
- What do publishers want and what are their processes?
- What kind of book are you writing (and why do you want to write it)?
- The 2 biggest mistakes.
- Homework: identifying your core message: Why This, Why Me, Why Now?
- Q & A.

Session 2: The nitty-gritty

- How long should my proposal be?
- Language and tone.
- The core of the proposal.
- Identifying the market.
- Identifying the competition.
- Selling yourself as an author
- Q & A.

Why do you want to publish a book?

- Professional necessity?
- “Because it’s there”?
- To communicate your message?
- To gain recognition?
- To make money?
- To use as a calling card/establish your authority?
- Because you want people to read it?

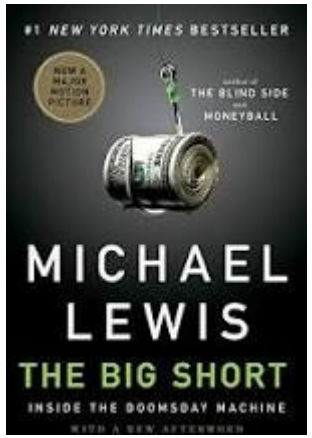
GOOD NEWS
BAD NEWS

Why write a book proposal?

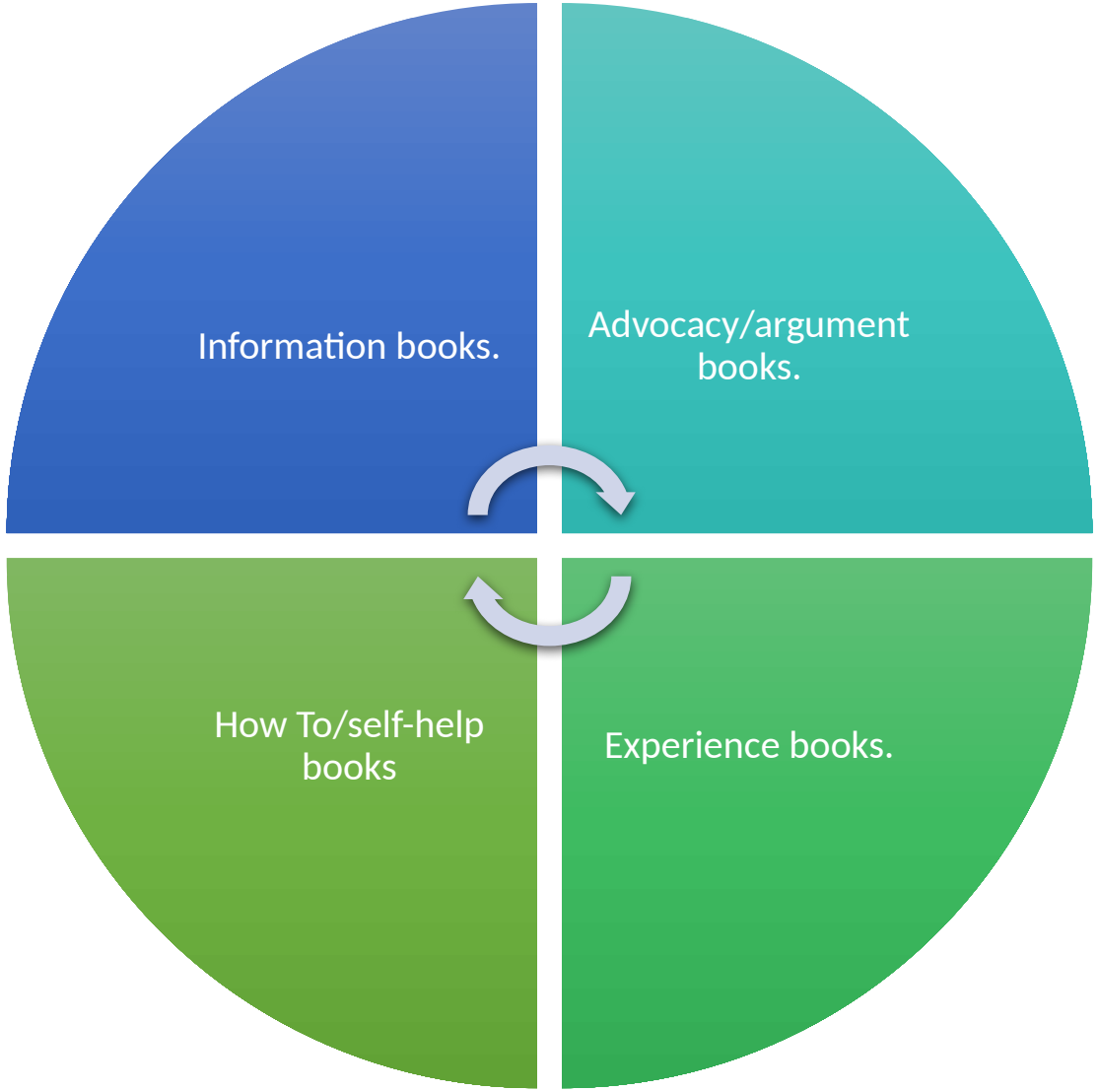
It helps you sharpen your message and develop your structure.

It presents your idea to the publisher/editor/reader in a concise form.

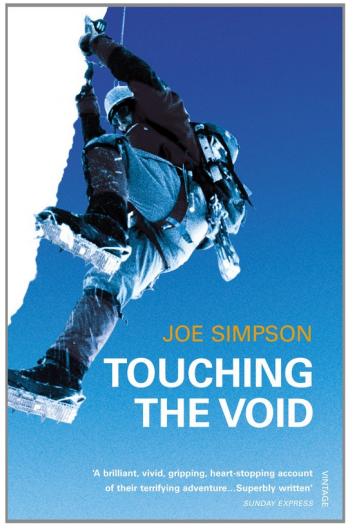
It is a way of helping the publisher give themselves permission to publish your book.

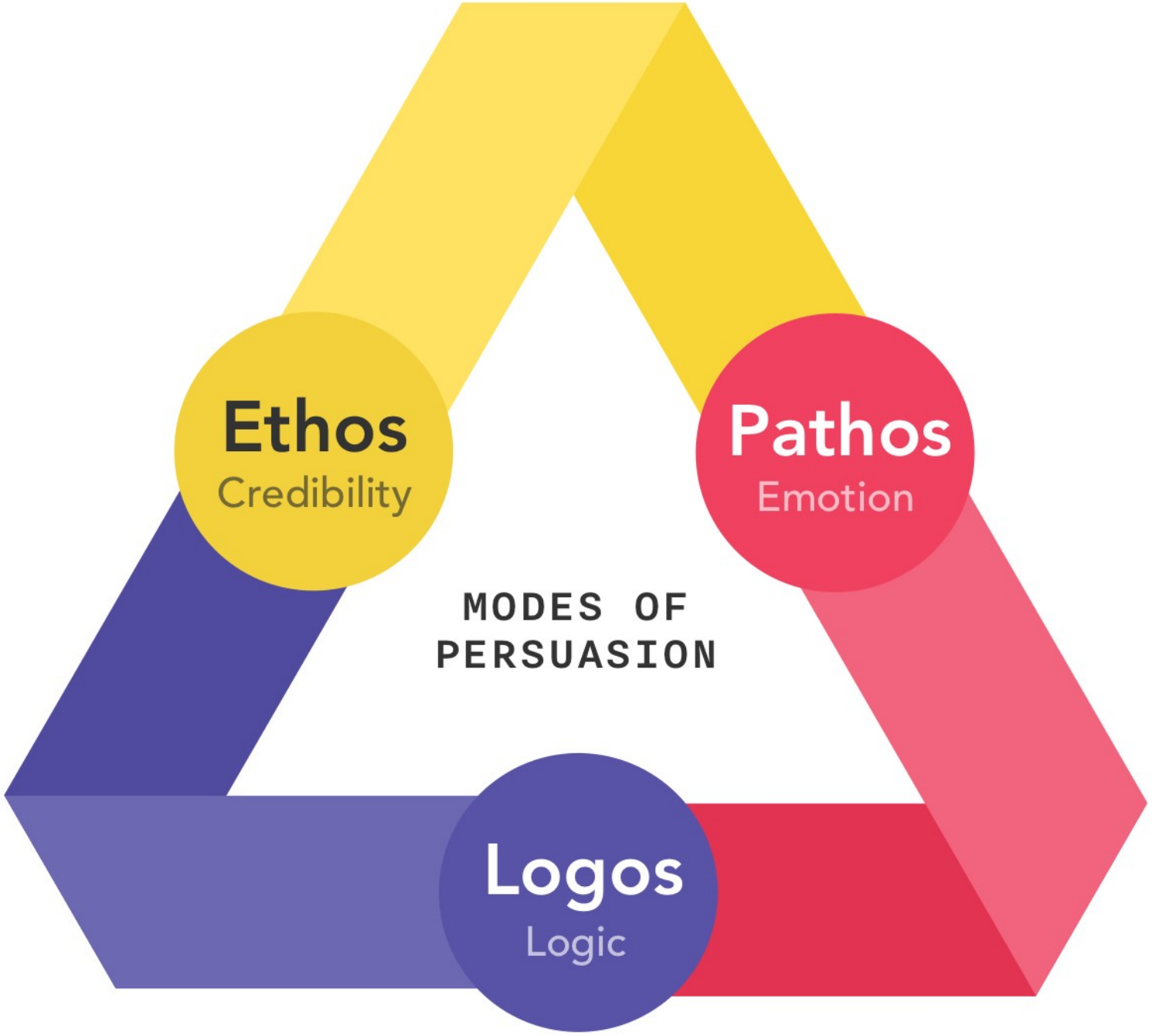

#1 NEW YORK TIMES BESTSELLER
THE BLIND SIDE
MONEYBALL
MICHAEL LEWIS
THE BIG SHORT
INSIDE THE DOOMSDAY MACHINE

Lend Me Your Ears
All you need to know about making speeches and presentations
Professor Max Atkinson

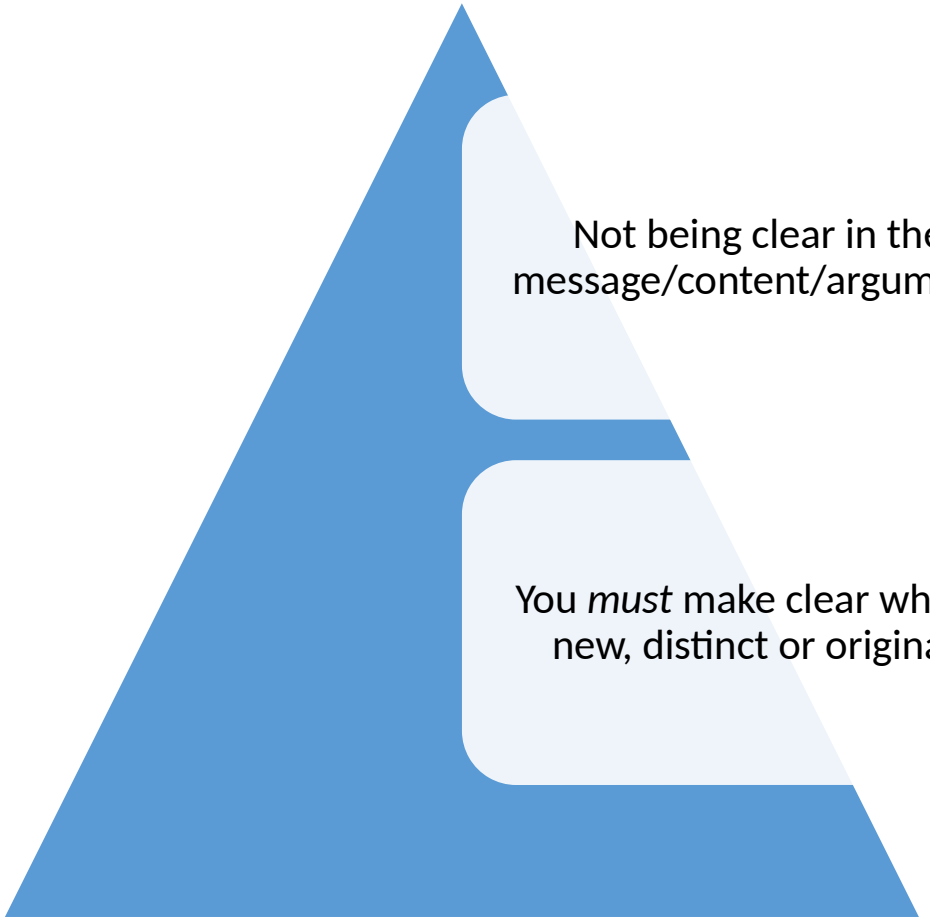

Information books.
Advocacy/argument books.
How To/self-help books
Experience books.

THE NO.1 SUNDAY TIMES BESTSELLER
Reni Eddo-Lodge
WHY I'M NO LONGER TALKING TO WHITE PEOPLE ABOUT RACE
BLOOMSBURY


JOE SIMPSON
TOUCHING THE VOID
'A brilliant, vivid, gripping, heart-stopping account of their terrifying adventure...Superbly written'
SUNDAY EXPRESS
VINTAGE


Ethos
Credibility
Pathos
Emotion
MODES OF
PERSUASION
Logos
Logic

Big mistake 1



Big mistake 2

Excess modesty/defensiveness; the language of “filling a gap”.

Assuming too much knowledge on the part of the person reading the proposal.

Why this?

Important/urgent societal issue?

Dramatic, moving story?

Will help people achieve X?

New (surprising) information?

To help right a wrong?

New analysis of familiar issue?

Experience in relevant field.

Lived experience.

Expertise, knowledge & skills.

Previous writing/publishing experience.

Media/podcasting experience.

Social media profile/email list.

Ability to make use of professional networks/conferences.

WHY NOW?

Current urgency of issue.

Increased public/media interest, likelihood of reviews (remember to deploy *evidence*).

Upcoming anniversaries.

New information only now available.

Need to capture historical memory.

Homework

This book does X (“helps people overcome their fears of A”, “reveals the untold history of B”, “makes a powerful case for C”, “tells of my struggle to overcome D”, etc.)

This topic is of vital importance because …

I am the ideal person to write it because …

This is a book which is extremely time because …